

SPECIAL EVENTS

PHASES OF THE MOON

	FULL MOON	NEW MOON
2020	March 9	March 24
2021	March 28	March 13
2022	March 18	March 2
2023	March 7	March 21
2024	March 25	March 10
2025	March 14	March 29
2026	March 3	March 19
2027	March 22	March 8

PLANETS

2020: March 31 Mars and Saturn appear two Moon-widths apart in the low eastern predawn sky.

2021: March 6 Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.4.

2022: March 20 Venus is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 4.4.

2023: March 2 Venus and Jupiter appear one Moon-width apart in the western early evening sky.

2024: March 24 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.1.

2025: March 20 Venus is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude -0.1.

2027: March 17 Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.4.

2028: March 12 Jupiter is at opposition, magnitude -2.0.

ECLIPSES

2025: March 14 A total eclipse of the Moon is visible from the Pacific; North, Central, and South America; western Europe; and western Africa.

2025: March 19 A partial eclipse of the Sun is visible from northwest Africa, Europe, and north Russia.

2026: March 3 A total eclipse of the Moon is visible from northwest North America, the Pacific Ocean, the far northeast of Asia and eastern Australasia, as well as the Arctic and Antarctica.

MARCH

Nights grow shorter in the Northern Hemisphere but longer in the Southern Hemisphere as the Sun moves toward the equinox on March 20. On that date, the Sun lies exactly on the celestial equator, and all over the world, day and night are of equal length. For northern observers, Orion and the other brilliant constellations of winter are departing toward the western horizon, while for southern observers, the rich star fields of Carina and Centaurus are moving to center stage.

NORTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

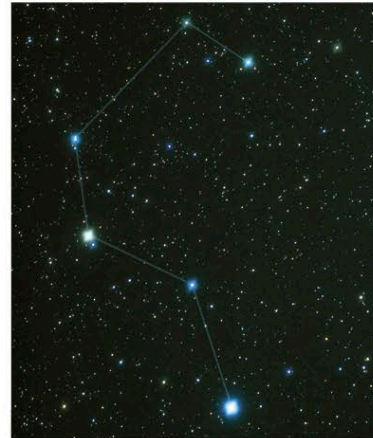
The distinctive sickle-shaped group of stars that makes up the head of Leo, the Lion, takes pride of place in the northern evening sky this month, with the fainter stars of Cancer to its right. Below it, in the south, lies a blank-looking area of sky occupied by the faint constellations Sextans, Crater, and Hydra. The only notable star in this area is 2nd-magnitude Alphard (in Hydra)—which, appropriately, means “the solitary one”—lying on the north-south meridian.

The saucepan shape of the Big Dipper rides high in the northeast, its handle pointing down toward

the bright star Arcturus, in Boötes, which is the harbinger of northern spring. Closer again to the horizon is Spica in Virgo. In the west, the stars of Gemini and Auriga remain high, with Taurus and Orion lower down. Sirius twinkles near the southwest horizon.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

The beautiful spiral galaxy M81 (see p.314) in northern Ursa Major lies near the north-south meridian on March evenings and is detectable through binoculars in clear skies. Farther south, the Beehive cluster (see p.290), or M44, in Cancer remains well positioned for observation.



THE SICKLE OF LEO

The stars that represent the head and neck of Leo, the Lion, form a distinctive shape like a sickle or a reversed question mark.

NEPTUNE

